

CAREER PATHS

Prospective railroad engineers must first pass a series of aptitude tests and medical examinations. Once they have qualified, engineers undergo further training specific to the route and class of train on which they will be operating.

RAIL TECHNICIAN While most firms require drivers to be 21, you can join a rail technician apprenticeship out of high school. This can lead to a trainee engineer job.

TRAINEE You can apply for a place as a trainee engineer with a national or regional rail company, then undergo practical and theoretical training to qualify as an engineer.



RAILROAD ENGINEER

As well as controlling the train, you must check the engine and the train's systems before setting off and follow line-side signals. With experience, you can move into training, safety, or management roles.



ENGINEER TRAINER

Instructs new recruits to become engineers, training them in railroad regulations, signals, the principles of train movement and handling, and route awareness.



TRAIN SAFETY INSPECTOR

Assesses other train engineers to ensure they are working efficiently and safely by accompanying them on train trips and simulations to ensure that safety standards are met.



LIGHT-RAIL TRAIN ENGINEER

Operates passenger trains or trams on urban underground and light-rail services. This specialized role involves rapid passenger transfers and frequent stops.



TRAIN OPERATIONS MANAGER

Works in a management position for a train operating company, overseeing engineer routes, schedule changes, and the maintenance and deployment of trains.

SKILLS GUIDE



Attention to detail in order to interpret line-side signals and follow rules and procedures.



Good communication skills for answering customer inquiries when not in the driver's cab.



Strong problem-solving skills to resolve issues, such as service delays or a lack of trains or staff.



Physical and mental resilience to concentrate for long periods of time while driving at high speed.



A willingness to work flexibly when colleagues are absent or services are disrupted.



TOURIST TRAIN DRIVER

Operates trains on themed or heritage railroads, including vintage or steam-powered engines, which require specialized skills to operate.